A GUIDE TO OLD ENGLISH

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I COMPOUNDING

§137 The process of forming new words or compounds by joining together two separate words which already exist was common in OE. Some of the possible arrangements are exemplified below.

Nouns can be formed by combining

1 Noun and noun, e.g. *hell-waran* (masc. pl.) 'inhabitants of hell', *niht-waco* (fem.) 'night-watch', *scip-rāp* (masc.) 'ship-rope', *storm-sǣ* (masc. or fem.) 'stormy sea';

2 Adjective and noun, e.g. *eall-wealda* (masc.) 'ruler of all', *hēah-clif* (neut.) 'high cliff', *hēah-ġerēfa* (masc.) 'high reeve, chief officer', *wīd-sǣ* (masc. or fem.) '(open) sea';

3 Adverb and noun, e.g. *ǣr-dæġ* (masc.) 'early day, first dawn', *eft-sīþ* (masc.) 'return', *inn-faru* (fem.) 'expedition', *inn-gang* (masc.) 'entrance'.

Adjectives are found consisting of

1 Noun and adjective, e.g. *ælmes-ġeorn* 'alms-eager, generous, charitable', *ār-weorþ* 'honour-worthy, venerable', *dōm-ġeorn* 'eager for glory', *mere-wērig* 'sea-weary';

2 Adjective and adjective, e.g. *hēah-þungen* 'of high rank', *hrēow-ċearig* 'sad' (lit. 'sad-anxious'), *wīd-cūþ* 'widely known', *wīs-hycgende* 'wise-thinking';

3 Adverb and adjective, e.g. *ǣr-gōd* 'very good', *forþ-ġeorn* 'forth-eager, eager to advance', *wel-þungen* 'well-thriven, excellent', *wel-willende* 'well-wishing, benevolent';

4 Adjective and noun, e.g. *blanden-feax* 'having mixed hair, gray-haired', *blīþe-mōd* 'of kindly mind, friendly', *hrēowiġ-mōd* 'gloomy-minded, sad', *salu-pād* 'dark-coated'.

In all these words the first element is uninflected; cf. *folc-lagu* (fem.) 'law of the people, public law' with *Godes* (gen.) *lagu* 'God's law' and *wīn-druncen* 'wine-drunk' with *bēore* (dat.) *druncen* 'drunk with beer'. But occasionally compounds do occur with an inflected first element, e.g. *Engla-lond* 'land of the Angles, England' (but cf. *Frēs-lond* 'Frisian land, Frisia') and *eġes-full* 'full of terror, terrible, wonderful' (but cf. *synn-full* 'sinful').

Note
Compounds of three elements are sometimes found, e.g. *wulf-hēafod-trēo* (neut.) 'wolf-head-tree, gallows, cross'.

Today, when we are faced with a new object or idea, we often express it by a compound made up of foreign or of native elements, e.g. 'tele-gram' and 'astro-naut', but 'one-up-man-ship' and 'fall-out'. But OE more often

'translated' foreign words. Sometimes the elements of a foreign word were represented by OE equivalents, e.g. *god-spel* (neut.) 'good news', based on *evangelium*, for 'gospel',[1] *þrī-nes* (fem.) representing *Trini-tas* 'The Trinity', and Ælfric's grammatical terms *fore-set-nes* (fem.) for Lat. *prae-positio* 'preposition' and *betwux-āleġed-nes* (fem.) 'between-laid-ness' for Lat. *inter-jectio* 'interjection'. Sometimes the word was analysed into its concepts and these were rendered into English, e.g. two words for 'Pharisees' – *sundor-halgan* (masc. pl.) 'apart-holies' and *ǣ-lārēowas* (masc. pl.) 'law-teachers'. That these processes are now less natural for speakers of English can be seen in two ways. First, many native compounds such as *tungol-cræft* (masc.) 'star-craft' for 'astronomy' and *lār-hūs* (neut.) 'lore-house' for 'school' have disappeared from the language. Secondly, proposed replacements like the sixteenth-century 'hundreder' for 'centurion' or the nineteenth-century 'folk-wain' for 'bus' seem to us ridiculous, whereas the Germans use *Sauerstoff*, not 'Oxygen', and *Wasserstoff*, not 'Hydrogen'.

To help provide the many synonyms beginning with different letters which were essential for the *scop* (poet) working in the alliterative measure, the Anglo-Saxon poets made great use of compounds. Of special interest is the kenning, a sort of condensed metaphor in which (a) is compared to (b) without (a) or the point of the comparison being made explicit; thus one might say of the camel 'The desert-ship lurched on'. So the sea is *hwæl-weġ* (masc.) 'whale-way', a ship *ȳþ-hengest* (masc.) 'wave-horse', and a minstrel *hleahtor-smiþ* (masc.) 'laughter-smith'.

We find too that many set phrases inherited from the days when the poetry was composed orally survive in the lettered poetry. These 'oral-formulae' are set metrical combinations which could be varied according to the needs of alliteration. Thus the phrase 'on, over, across the sea' can be expressed by one of the prepositions *on, ofer, ġeond*, followed by the appropriate case of one of the following words: *bæþ-weġ* 'bath-way', *flōd-weġ* 'flood-way', *flot-weġ* 'sea-way', *hwæl-weġ* 'whale-way' (all masc.), *hran-rād* 'whale-road', *swan-rād* 'swan-road', and *seġl-rād* 'sail-road' (all fem.). References to further discussions on these points will be found in §§265–266.

II THE ADDITION OF AFFIXES

§138 These can be divided into prefixes – elements placed at the beginning of words to qualify their meaning – and suffixes. The effect of many which survive today is obvious; we may cite the prefix *mis-* as in *mis-dæd* (fem.) 'misdeed', prepositions or adverbs used as prefixes, e.g. *ofer-mæġen* (neut.) 'superior force' and *ūt-gān* 'go out', and, with suffixes, adjectives

[1] You should look up the noun 'gospel' in O.E.D. to find out why *godspel* has *ŏ* when the OE equivalent of 'good' is *gōd*.

ending in *-full*, *-isċ*, and *-leas*, e.g. *synn-full* 'sinful', *ċild-isċ* 'childish', and *feoh-lēas* 'moneyless, destitute', and nouns ending in *-dōm*, *-ere*, *-scipe* (all masc.) and *-nes*, *-nis*, *-nys* (fem.), e.g. *wīs-dōm* 'wisdom', *fisc-ere* 'fisherman', *frēond-scipe* 'friendship', and *beorht-nes* 'brightness'. Others which occur frequently but are not so easily recognizable are set out below.

Prefixes

ā-
1 Sometimes it means 'away', as in *ā-fȳsan* 'drive forth'.
2 But sometimes it seems to have no effect on the meaning, e.g. *ā-galan* 'sing'.

æġ-
It generalizes prons. and advs., e.g. *æġ-hwā* 'everyone' and *æġ-hwær* 'everywhere'.

be-
1 In some words *be-* is the same as the prep. 'about', e.g. *be-gān* 'surround' and *be-rīdan* 'ride round, surround'.
2 Sometimes it is a deprivative, e.g. *be-dælan* 'deprive' and *be-hēafdian* 'behead'.
3 It can make an intransitive verb transitive, e.g. *be-þenċan* 'think about' and *be-wēpan* 'bewail'.

for-
It is an intensifier, e.g. *for-bærnan* 'burn up, consume', *forelorenness* (fem.) 'perdition', and *for-heard* 'very hard'.

ġe-
1 In some nouns it has the sense of 'together', e.g. *ġe-fēra* (masc.) 'companion' and *ġe-brōþru* (masc. pl.) 'brothers'.
2 In verbs, it sometimes has a perfective sense, e.g. *ġe-āscian* 'find out' and *ġe-winnan* 'get by fighting, win'; hence its frequent use in past ptcs.

on-, an-
1 In verbs like *on-bindan* 'unbind' and *on-lūcan* 'unlock', it has a negative sense.
2 Sometimes it means 'against', as in *on-rǣs* (masc.) 'attack'.

or-
1 This is a deprivative in *or-mōd* 'without courage, despairing' and *or-sorg* 'without care, careless'.
2 It can also mean 'early, original, primaeval' (cf. *or* (neut.) 'beginning, origin'), e.g. *or-eald* 'of great age', *or-ieldu* (fem.) 'extreme old age', and *or-þanc* (masc.) 'inborn thought, ingenuity, skill'.

tō-
1 Sometimes it is the same as the prep. *tō*, e.g. *tō-cyme* (masc.) 'arrival' and *tō-weard* (prep.) 'towards'.
2 But with verbs it frequently means separation, e.g. *tō-drīfan* (trans.) 'drive apart, disperse, scatter' and *tō-faran* (intrans.) 'go apart, disperse'.

un-
1 This is sometimes a negative prefix, e.g. *un-friþ* (masc.) 'un-peace, war' and *un-hold* 'unfriendly'.
2 Sometimes it is pejorative, as in *un-ġiefu* (fem.) 'evil gift' and *un-weder* (neut.) 'bad weather'.

wan-
This is a deprivative or negative prefix, e.g. *wan-hāl* 'not hale, ill' and *wan-hoga* (masc.) 'thoughtless man'.

wiþ-
Its primary sense in compounds is 'against', e.g. *wiþ-cēosan* 'reject', *wiþ-cweþan* 'reply, contradict', *wiþ-drīfan* 'repel', and *wiþ-feohtend* (masc.) 'enemy, opponent, rebel'.

ymb-
This means 'around', e.g. *ymb-gang* (masc.) 'circuit, circumference' and *ymb-lædan* 'lead round'.

Suffixes

Nouns

-aþ, -oþ
This forms masc. nouns, e.g. *herg-aþ* 'plundering' and *fisc-oþ* 'fishing'.

-end
This equals '-er', as in *Hæl-end* (masc.) 'Healer, Saviour' and *wīġ-end* (masc.) 'fighter, warrior'. It derives from the pres. ptc. ending *-ende*.

-hād
This introduces masc. nouns and equals MnE '-hood', as in *ċild-hād* 'childhood' and *woruld-hād* 'secular life'.

-ing
1 In masc. nouns it means 'son of', e.g. *Ælfred Æþelwulf-ing* 'Alfred son of Æthelwulf', or 'associated with', e.g. *earm-ing* 'wretch' and *hōr-ing* 'adulterer, fornicator'.
2 In fem. nouns, it equals *-ung*; see below.

-mæl
1 The noun *mæl* (neut.) 'measure, fixed time' appears in compound nouns, e.g. *fōt-mæl* (neut.) 'foot's length, foot' and (with the dat. pl. used adverbially; see §191.3) *floc-mælum* 'in (armed) bands' and *ġēar-mælum* 'year by year'.
2 In the sense 'mark, sign', it appears in compound nouns, e.g. *fȳr-mæl* (neut.) 'fire-mark', and also in compound adjectives; see below.

-rædden
This forms fem. abstract nouns, e.g. *hierd-rædden* 'guardian-ship, care, guard'.

-þ(o), -þ(u)
This is used to form fem. abstract nouns, e.g. *fæh-þ(o)* 'hostility' and *ierm-þ(u)* 'misery, poverty'. Note that *ġeogoþ* 'youth' is fem.

-ung, -ing
This is found in fem. abstract nouns formed from verbs, e.g. *bod-ung* 'preaching' and *rād-ing* 'reading'.

Adjectives

-en
1 This is the ending of past ptcs. of strong verbs.
2 It is also found in adjectives with an *i*-mutated vowel in the stem, e.g. *ættr-en* 'poisonous' and *gyld-en* 'golden'.

-iġ This equals MnE '-y', as in *cræft-iġ* 'powerful, mighty' and *hāl-iġ* 'holy'.

-liċ This, originally the same word as *līċ* (neut.) 'body', equals MnE '-ly, -like', e.g. *heofon-liċ* 'heavenly' and *ċild-liċ* 'child-like, childish'.

-mæl This element, listed above under Nouns, also occurs in compound adjectives, e.g. *græg-mæl* 'of a grey colour', *hring-mæl* 'ring-marked, ornamented with a ring', and *wunden-mæl* 'with curved markings'.

-sum This occurs in words like *wynn-sum* 'delightful, pleasant' (cf. 'winsome') and *hīer-sum* 'hear-some, obedient'.

Adverbs

See §135.

Verbs

-an The most common infinitive ending for strong and weak verbs. (For the *-an* in class 1 weak verbs, which was originally **-jan*, see Appendix B.)

-ian The infinitive ending for class 2 weak verbs. Verbs borrowed from Latin are usually conjugated according to this class, e.g. *declinian* 'decline' < *declināre* and *predician* 'preach' < *praedi-cāre*.

-rian See §132.1.

-sian This is the infinitive ending of a subclass of weak 2 verbs formed from adjectives and nouns, e.g. *clǣnsian* 'cleanse' and *rīcsian* 'be powerful, reign'.

-ettan This infinitive ending is used to form a subclass of weak 1 verbs from adjectives and nouns, e.g. *lāþ-ettan* 'hate, loathe', *līc-ettan* 'pretend', and *sār-ettan* 'lament'.

-lǣċan This infinitive ending is also used to form a subclass of weak 1 verbs from adjectives and nouns, e.g. *ġe-ān-lǣċan* 'unite' and *ġe-þwǣr-lǣċan* 'consent'.

5

Syntax

INTRODUCTION

§139 Syntax has been described as the study of 'the traffic rules of language'. If this is so, you are offered here only a simplified Anglo-Saxon highway code, designed to deal with constructions likely to worry the beginner. OE syntax is recognizably English; in some passages the word-order at least is almost without exception that of MnE. At other times, we seem to be wrestling with a foreign language. Some of the difficulties arise from idiosyncrasies due to the Germanic ancestry of OE. Another reason, which obtains mostly in the early writings when OE prose was in a formative state, is that Alfred and his companions were struggling to develop the language as a vehicle for the expression of complicated narrative and abstract thought. They achieved no little success, but had their failures too. The breathless but vigorous account of the Battle of Ashdown (the annal for 871 in the Parker MS of the Anglo-Saxon Chronicle), which sweeps us along on a surging current of simple sentences joined by *ond*, is not untypical of the early efforts of prose writers who were not translating from Latin. There is only one complex sentence in the whole piece (the last but one). That the writer gets into trouble with it is symptomatic; cf. the account of the sea-battle of 897 in the same manuscript, where what has happened is not particularly clear on first reading. This inability to cope with complicated ideas is more apparent in the translated texts, where the influence of the Latin periodic structure often produces stilted prose, as in the story of Orpheus and Eurydice in King Alfred's translation of Boethius. Even Alfred's original prose is sometimes twisted in the same way, e.g. the sentences discussed in §172. Perhaps Latin, being the language of the Church, the language from which many works were translated, and the only model available, was accorded a status denied to it (or to any other original) today.

§140 Another source of difficulty becomes apparent from a study of the major differences between OE and MnE. It is sometimes said that OE is the period of full inflexions, ME the period of levelled inflexions (all with the vowel *e*, e.g. *-e, -es, -en*, as opposed to the endings of OE with their different vowels), and MnE the period of no inflexions. This statement points to the vital truth that MnE depends on word-order and prepositions to make distinctions which in an inflected language are made by the case endings.

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